

Interview with kessog chan - solutions analyst Interview

Megan Kemp with Kessog Chan

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Kessog Chan ▶ 0:01

Hello. Hello, Megan. Hello.

Megan Kemp ▶ 0:04

How are you? How's your day going?

Kessog Chan ▶ 0:06

I'm great, thank you. The weather is really nice today.

Megan Kemp ▶ 0:10

Are you based in London?

Kessog Chan ▶ 0:12

Yeah, I'm based in London currently.

Megan Kemp ▶ 0:14

Nice. Yeah, it's a little bit cooler.

Kessog Chan ▶ 0:17

How about you? Where are you based in?

Megan Kemp ▶ 0:21

Yeah, I'm also in London actually, so it's a little bit cooler now, isn't it?

Kessog Chan ▶ 0:25

Yeah, the weather is like much better than the heatwave week.

Megan Kemp ▶ 0:29

Yeah, definitely, it's much more bearable. I feel like when it was the heatwave, it's really hard to concentrate when you're like hot.

Kessog Chan ▶ 0:36

Exactly, without an air conditioner, that's a nightmare.

Megan Kemp ▶ 0:40

Yeah, exactly, 100%. Um, thank you so much for taking the time to chat with me.

Kessog Chan

► 0:47

Thank you for having me.

Megan Kemp

► 0:48

No worries, this will just be like a really casual chat and hopefully I can answer any questions that you've got about Cognia or like the role. Um, oh, I've seen note-takers in the lobby. Do you want me to add them in, or do you want me to just maybe send you the transcript from this call after?

Kessog Chan

► 1:04

Yeah, yeah, that would be great if you could send me the transcript after the meeting here.

Megan Kemp

► 1:08

Yeah, of course, no problem. But yeah, I could start maybe giving you like a little bit of an introduction and a bit of information about the role, if that's helpful.

Kessog Chan

► 1:17

Yeah, that would be great.

Megan Kemp

► 1:19

Amazing. So I'm Meg. I've been at Cognia actually 6 months today. working in like the sort of tech and product recruitment side of things. Um, Cognia turned 3 back in May this year and, um, was founded by our founder Ben and our technical co-founder Lars. Ben had previously founded another company which is called FiveAI. That was like an autonomous, like, driving company that scaled up to about 300 people, and then they eventually exited to Bosch for around £400 million. Lars was one of the first engineers that Ben had hired there. So they've got a strong track record of building, scaling, and then going through the successful exit.

Kessog Chan

► 2:00

Amazing.

Megan Kemp

► 2:01

But despite the success of Five, Ben really felt like he'd failed at the end of that because he wanted to create something that had real-world impact and something that was tangible, making a difference in the real world. And that's where Cognia comes along. So we're essentially going after the physical industries, the kind of companies that keep the lights on and keep things moving. So think like your gas, electric, water kind of infrastructure. And these big companies are kind of typically held back by legacy systems and outdated ways of working. But yeah, Cognia is essentially like an AI software factory, and it allows for customers to talk about their problems in plain, non-technical language, and it will start spinning up apps as solutions for those problems. And the role of the solutions team is super, super important in that. The solutions team will be involved from the very beginning, like the first kind of, um, like intro call with a customer, and then they'll be like scoping out the problems, becoming like super familiar with the, um, the customer's problem space, and like using data to really understand like where we can have the most impact sort of quickly, um, and

then taking that relationship all the way through to like the implementation of the chosen solution, um, And then hopefully making the customers have like such a great experience with their first app that they maybe want to go and create loads more with us.

Kessog Chan

► 3:24

Mm-hmm.

Megan Kemp

► 3:25

And we're hoping to close our Series B fundraising towards the end of this year, which is why we're looking to hire some more people into the solutions roles at the moment. The, the current setup of the team is we have James, who's like the VP of Solutions, then we have 2 directors, and then we have about 4 or 5 other solutions, um, people within the team as well. And we're looking to bring in people at kind of all levels. So we've got a director role open, we have a solution strategist role open, which is more of like a senior role, and then we have the Solutions Analyst as well. But, um, yeah, I'll stop talking. Did you maybe want to give me an intro to you?

Kessog Chan

► 4:00

Yeah, definitely. Okay, um, so I'm Kessog. Thanks for having me today. So I am a pre-sales consultant, uh, with 6 years of experience across different, um, operational and technical problems into solutions.

Megan Kemp

► 4:14

I turn—

Kessog Chan

► 4:14

I translate them into solutions for the different teams that can deliver into real-world impact. And currently, I work in Solution Pre-Sales at Huawei, based in London. I support a Tier 1 UK mobile network operator, which is Hutchison 3G.

Megan Kemp

► 4:34

Okay.

Kessog Chan

► 4:35

And I lead the discovery and product selection process with the customer engineers, uncovering the technical constraints behind the requirements and turn this those insights and findings, like an intro call into something, a solution scope, where we are aligned with this to pursue the team that we can commit and validate it. So before Huawei, I was a technical product manager at Bank of China. So I am a product manager of a regulated product, which is the ZPay. So that role gave me an end-to-end delivery experience, And for one regulatory mandate, I translate them, the requirements from the regulatory authorization across compliance, operations, and engineering. And then I delivered the feature within a hard timeframe and meeting all their mandatory requirements and also being responsible for the user adoption rate as well. So, and before that, where I start my career journey, I started at Apple where I worked across B2B sales and operational analytics. So that gave— that experience gave me a strong commercial and data foundation. So I helped them solving retail operation problem using different data, including, you know, supply chain and

procurement as well. So yeah, that's pretty much big picture of how my career goes. And before I get into Huawei, where I first landed in the UK, I actually did my business analytics master's degree in University of Exeter. And so yeah, that's pretty much how I started my UK journey here.

Megan Kemp

► 6:26

Yeah.

Kessog Chan

► 6:27

Yeah, I think in a conclusion, like doing a summary overall for my career path and my academic path is I consistently work between operators and engineers and I also clients. I translate them, you know, different kinds of human communication into a very consolidated scope of projects, of solutions, and also leading all the way from discovery to delivery. And I think that's also the major drive why I would like to land on Cognia. I think the current role is really matching with what I want to deepen in my expertise. So Yeah, that's my introduction.

Megan Kemp

► 7:12

Yeah, amazing. Thank you so much for walking me through that. And was there anything that jumped out to you about the role at Cognia that made you want to apply?

Kessog Chan

► 7:21

I would say actually what you just described is exactly the reason why I feel like ticked when I saw the role. So what genuinely interests me about Cognia is that the solution it's offering is impacting beyond the system itself, but doing, you know, actual physical impacts. And that's where I want to deliver, also where I want to contribute as well in the Internet of Things industry. So Cognia, with the organization operating physical infrastructure where data may come from assets or field operations, enterprise systems, these, while the decisions are also shaped by the regulation and expert knowledge, it turns all the all this information into software that helps actual people making faster or reliable decisions in the physical world. And that connects closely with how I experience in my career. So at Huawei, I worked between software engineers, which is a physical telecom network, and Bank of China, I translated complex regulatory mandates. And I think it holds— it kind of caught my eye at the very first glance when I read through the roles, and it also matches my ideal contribution, which is doing real-world impact. And I think that's pretty much aligned with what you just introduced earlier.

Megan Kemp

► 8:53

Yeah.

Kessog Chan

► 8:54

Yeah, I think this is a very, very precious opportunity to me to find a role and land in the IoT industry in contributing what I have been building along my career path.

Megan Kemp

► 9:06

Yeah, amazing. Thank you so much for doing some research and stuff as well. That's super helpful. Yeah, I have a couple of role-specific questions if that would be okay, and then there'll be some time for you to ask me some. So I was going to ask, what would you say is the most complex customer problem that you've

solved?

Kessog Chan

► 9:26

Okay, so in terms of complex, it reminds me of the time where I have to put together a feature under the Bank of China app. So it's a regulation feature. So, okay, so it started off with I was handed over this requirements from the regulatory authorization where they need a fraud detection, fraud detection feature delivered within 14 days. Like 14 days I have to gather all the requirements from different kind of system involved in the scope and then turning, turning the feature, which is able to identify impossible trouble for user login. So, being— so in order to ship it within 14 days, there was one big challenge, which is the procurement process within the bank is not allowing this to happen. The procurement process itself will already take over a month, and it will stop me from delivering the feature, deploying the feature on live within 14 days. What I do is decided to roll out the feature in phases. What we have to procure from the vendors is actually the GeoIP address from reliable sources. What I do is to roll out the feature using open-source data instead of procuring from vendors. And I think what I solve here is being able to identify that when there is a product conflict, it's not necessary to sacrifice the product quality in order to fulfill the time frame. So what I do here is deploy it in the first first phases to use open source data. Then in parallel, we do procurement process internally, and this helps to meet the regulation timeframe hardly and able to, you know, protect the product quality, being able to secure the user experience as well. So looking back, I think what I— what what secured the win here for me is that I'm not being scoped by the limited requirements, but I was able to identify the underlying goal of different stakeholders and try to figure out a solution that protects both of them.

Megan Kemp

► 12:15

Yeah, nice, amazing. Thank you so much for walking me through that. And have you got an example of maybe once you have scoped something out for a customer and like the deal's been agreed, that you've then taken it through implementation? And if you do, what did that sort of phase look like?

Kessog Chan

► 12:35

Scoping something for a customer. Okay. Okay. So I'm currently a pre-sales consultant at Huawei. So I cover one of the client's technical workshops where the— with the pursuit team and from the client's company. So my job there was to make sure that the scope was real rather than assumed. So I walked through the full requirement cycle, 3 technical workshops, and a structured analysis session with the engineer stakeholders. I first mapped their objectives and their current environment first. Then I separated the genuine must-haves from the preferences.

Megan Kemp

► 13:21

Mm-hmm.

Kessog Chan

► 13:22

So after that, I tested a small scope of solution. which we are both aligned with in order to, you know, demonstrate the value that we are offering against the European— which is a feature against European regulatory constraints, which the scope is around 6 of the subnets, account subnets. So I write up the scope, the risk, the owners, and what are the aligned next steps for our 5-person pursuit team. And the bid went out built on requirements the customer— oh, bless you.

Megan Kemp ▶ 13:56

Sorry about that.

Kessog Chan ▶ 13:57

No worries. Bless you.

Megan Kemp ▶ 13:59

Thank you. Hit nose.

Kessog Chan ▶ 14:01

The bid went out based on the requirements that the customers had confirmed themselves, and we stopped carrying out the risk of promising something nobody had validated. So at Cogna, I think this is where I can apply my experience in the discovery. It's literally the revenue gate where you only invoice when the app proves the value. So a scope the customer owns, engineers have confirmed it, is what they really could eye up, being able to see how we value, how our solution value to their business. So it turns a discovery into a delivery where we can get paid for.

Megan Kemp ▶ 14:46

Yeah. Yeah, amazing. And could you talk to me a little bit about how you are using AI tools in your day-to-day work at the moment?

Kessog Chan ▶ 14:54

Okay, so as a person being working in a lot of enterprise, I've been scoping a lot, sourcing different AI tools to help with my work. Most of the enterprise are actually in the situation where most of the Cogna customers are at, where they are doing a lot of systems which are not connected and it's always a manual work to put everything together. So I can share an example where I use AI tools and Coden to help my day-to-day work.

Megan Kemp ▶ 15:33

Sure.

Kessog Chan ▶ 15:36

So this was a time when we are— it was a time when I was in Huawei, and there is around like 60 to 80 live sample units moving against the product launch deadlines, and the customer selection workshop. So the process relied on the manual testing every single active sample each day, which is a huge manual work, and manual assembling sign-off documents as well. So whenever the samples is being tested, I have to manually generate a sign-off document customized for that unit and then send it to a customer. So the process relied on manual testing, and at that scale, which is 60 to 80 of the units, it creates a risk that the evaluation unit could reach the customer team later than what we expected, later than due date deadline, and might affect the— it can cause impact to the pursuit timeline. So I wrote a VBA automation that works between the Excel and the Word document, and a schedule task that checks the live sample records like How when when are they tested? Have they finished the testing already? And and turning and it meant the process relied sorry so so I I wrote a VBA automation and a scheduled test that connects different different stages generating deadline reminders producing sign-off documents in a standard template. It removes the need from daily

manual check and save around hours in the week on document assembly. So most importantly, it helped keep the evaluation program moving smoothly so that the product reached the customer's evaluation team before the key decision points. So I— yeah, so this is an example how I, you know, streamline everything, and that requires a lot of manual hours into something using AI.

Megan Kemp

► 17:43

Yeah.

Kessog Chan

► 17:43

I think this is somewhere, a very specific case where we use AI and coding to help streamline some procedures. But there are also some times that I use AI to help with brainstorming. Personally, I am a deep AI user, so I have Claude subscription and ChatGPT and Gemini as well. I personally use AI a lot in the brainstorming procedure where I created a proposal before. Like, I brainstorm a lot to uncover some key pieces of information that I don't know I don't know.

Megan Kemp

► 18:30

Yeah.

Kessog Chan

► 18:30

Unknown unknowns. So I think that's where I use AI the most because it's always surprised me a lot that there are some key pieces you might not be aware of, and it's like opening a new door to a complete new room that you didn't even realize it exists. So yes, I personally use a lot in, in the brainstorming and discovering unknown unknowns procedures.

Megan Kemp

► 18:55

Yeah. Nice. Yeah, amazing. And my last question is like, could you maybe tell me about a time you were hit with an unfamiliar problem and there was no one there to kind of hold your hand through that? What did you do?

Kessog Chan

► 19:11

Let me think about that. Okay, this reminds me a time when I was in Bank of China. So as a product manager, I am also a key contact between different systems. And it was a leader Asking, requiring to understand what's the current situation of different systems. And this has not been done, like, this has not been done by any people in my team before. Like, people, the first solution coming up from people, different people's mind, will be asking each system leads one by one, which is over 20 manual contacts, and it requires a lot of It's a very time-consuming task. So, and what I thought of is I go back to the leaders, I ask, what is this for? What is the scope of this task? Why are you asking this? And is this going to be something happening in the long run? So is it going to be repeated? So understanding the full context of this task, I was able to identify that the solution wasn't asking one by one, but instead Instead, it's going to be something repeating every week or even every month or even every week. So I decided to propose a solution. So I decided to build a Grafana dashboard, which is a system health check dashboard that allows the leaders to be able to check on each system in one glance instead of contacting every system lead To ask for how's the system going. So I proposed a solution with a lot of conversation with the engineering team to identify is it feasible and how is it going to work between the internal teams. So I put together all the requirements and the workflows

and then proposed it to the leaders and this was officially landed a new project within the team and within the department. And, and we are able to streamline all 30 systems, system health check, within one dashboard. And once I was— we started with a small scope of system, which is around 5 to 10 systems, the first phases, and then we extended once we got this— once we got the dashboard running smoothly. between the 10 systems, and it was then become one of the major tools that the leadership used in the later times to do major decisions on checking how everything's going.

Megan Kemp

► 22:09

Yeah, nice, amazing. Thank you so much for answering all my questions. I've got some logistics ones, but I'll come back to those. And what questions do you have for me?

Kessog Chan

► 22:19

Yes, so I am curious about What are the major qualities the hiring team is prioritizing at this moment? Like, as a Solutions Analyst, I know the scope of the job duties, but which of those are the very major important ones?

Megan Kemp

► 22:40

Yeah, definitely. I would say like up there would definitely be like the technical skills. So being able to kind of pull apart like data and using like Python and SQL to kind of yeah, tell a story with data. I think that's like quite high up there. I would say like having that real like curiosity to get like really deep into problems. So like really wanting to deeply understand like how things work and being able to like embed yourself almost in a customer's problem to really deeply understand how we can best solve it. And then I would say the last one's about kind of Like having like a kind of high agency attitude. So things at Cogna can move quite quickly, and being able to really like prioritize and like work on the things that need to get done in order to kind of get customers over the line, and having that sort of, um, like, you know, don't put off today what tomorrow what you could do today, that kind of thing. Like just doing the thing that needs to be done.

Kessog Chan

► 23:45

Um.

Megan Kemp

► 23:46

I think they're the top 3. So yeah, the technical skills, that kind of agency, and what was the other one I said?

Kessog Chan

► 23:54

And also curiosity.

Megan Kemp

► 23:56

Curiosity. Yes. Yeah.

Kessog Chan

► 23:59

Yes. It was about asking the right questions and being able to, you know, identify what's the client facing, right? I'd say also, if this role landed, what type of customer problem and engagement would the company expect that a successful Candidate could work on first?

Megan Kemp

► 24:20

Yeah, for sure. That one's a little bit trickier to answer because the kind of problems that we solve are quite broad, and we don't have in our mind, like, say, when we hire this specific person that they're going to be working with which client. We'll kind of be like, because we have quite a lean team, the teams aren't kind of separated into sort of like sectors or specific problem spaces. It's more like, for this analyst role, What we envision is that they'll be working maybe more closely with customers that we already have as opposed to customers that are like pre-being closed. And they'll be focusing probably to begin with more on like how can we grow those accounts. So say we've already solved like one problem for a company, getting really involved in like the kind of data that we've got from that and finding out like what would be the next best problem to solve. So yeah, it's not too kind of like company or sector specific at the moment.

Kessog Chan

► 25:22

So would you say the company is like, the KPI for this role is to renew current customers or extending new customers?

Megan Kemp

► 25:32

It will be a mixture of both. Yeah, so part of it will be working alongside like the solution strategists and the solution directors on sort of gaining new business, but another part of it will be on like growth and expanding the business that we already have.

Kessog Chan

► 25:49

I see. So it was like 50/50 for the current stage right now?

Megan Kemp

► 25:54

Yes. Yeah, I would say. I see.

Kessog Chan

► 25:56

And yes, I think, okay, one more question. I'm thinking about the people already in the team that they're doing very well. What is the demonstration? What did they demonstrate in the first 6 months that you can imagine they fit very well into the team we have currently?

Megan Kemp

► 26:25

Yeah, really good question. I think it's that kind of ability to come in and really quickly throw yourself in the deep end at Getting involved with stuff. Like, Cogna is quite a complex product.

Kessog Chan

► 26:42

Mm-hmm.

Megan Kemp

► 26:43

I would say it's about like trying to like really deeply understand like both how Cogna works, but also like how our customers are using it. So like taking the time to go through like some of our existing apps and someone that's— I think it's that curiosity piece again that like really wants to get under the hood and

understand like why things are working. And then being able to kind of translate that into working with new customers as well and kind of just, yeah, throwing yourself in at the deep end, I think is probably similar in most startups, but definitely here where it's quite sort of customer-focused.

Kessog Chan

► 27:20

So it's really important to have a very big picture of how the business runs in order to connect different points within the daily conversation and daily operations. operations to transform them, translate them into something that we can offer to our customers.

Megan Kemp

► 27:36

Yeah.

Kessog Chan

► 27:37

That sounds very familiar. Okay, yeah, that pretty much shapes how the team works and how this role contributes within the team. And yeah, I think this is pretty much the questions that I want to ask at this space right now. How do you find our conversation, Meg?

Megan Kemp

► 27:56

Yeah, Really good, thank you. I have a couple of quick logistics questions for you if that would be okay.

Kessog Chan

► 28:03

Okay, yeah, yeah.

Megan Kemp

► 28:05

Are you based in London? Yes.

Kessog Chan

► 28:08

Perfect.

Megan Kemp

► 28:09

And do you have the right to work in the UK or do you require any support?

Kessog Chan

► 28:13

No support, I can do a full working rights. It's just right now my visa will be valid until 2027, but then I can extend it within without any restriction. It's the BNO visa, just to let you know. Cool, nice.

Megan Kemp

► 28:35

And how long is your notice period?

Kessog Chan

► 28:39

Currently it requires 6 months— oh, sorry, 6 weeks on contract, but I can use my holiday to shorten this a bit.

Megan Kemp

► 28:49

Okay, nice. No problem. And last question is around salary. Do you have a salary expectation in mind for your next role?

Kessog Chan

► 29:01

I am expecting the range between £60,000 to £70,000, but I am still very open to discuss over the whole package and, you know, the learning opportunity. Right now I can see there is a very Matching learned career path between the role and myself. So I'm open to discuss for the overall package. Yeah.

Megan Kemp

► 29:27

Okay, perfect. Amazing. So what I'm going to do is just align with the team on everything we've spoken about today, and then I'll come back to you and let you know about the next steps, and we can go from there. I'll try to get back to you by, like, Thursday this week, if that's okay. We have an offsite on Wednesday. So yeah.

Kessog Chan

► 29:46

Okay, just to clarify, it's \$60K per annum?

Megan Kemp

► 29:51

Yes, perfect.

Kessog Chan

► 29:52

\$60K per annum, okay, great. Thank you, thank you for your time today. Thank you, have a great rest of your day. You too, bye-bye.